The Shape of Ordinary Days

Chapter One · The Lower Shelf

An excerpt from an imagined memoir, written to show how we work with voice, scene and dialogue when a book is drawn from lived experience. The narrator returns home after a long stay in the hospital; the chapter follows their first day and the morning after.

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The key stuck the way it always had, half a turn and then nothing, and Nell said, "Let me," and I said, "I've got it," and for a while we stood on the front step with my hand on the key and hers held an inch above it, not quite touching.

The trick is to lift the door by the handle as you turn. I had known that for eleven years. It took me three tries to remember it.

Inside, the first thing was the smell. Not a bad one—radiator dust, the cedar block in the coat closet, something faintly like oranges—just the smell of my own house, which I had apparently never noticed while I was living in it. I stood in the hall and breathed it in and felt, absurdly, like a guest.

"Do you want to sit down?" Nell said.

"I've been sitting down since February."

"That isn't an answer."

It wasn't. There was a bench by the door that hadn't been there before, a low pine thing with a cushion tied on at the corners, placed exactly where I would stand to take off my shoes. I looked at it. Nell watched me look at it.

"It was forty dollars," she said. "You're allowed to hate it."

"I don't hate it."

I sat on it. My shoes were the ones I'd been wearing the day I left, and somebody—Nell—had cleaned them. The laces were new. I undid them slowly, partly because my hands were slow and partly because I didn't want to stand up again just yet in front of her, and she knew that, and went into the kitchen to make a noise with the kettle so I could do it without an audience.

That is the kind of sister she is. It is also the kind of sister she is that she called out, "Take your time!" from the kitchen, which undid most of the good.

THE HOUSE HAD been kept beautifully, and it was not quite mine.

The mail was stacked on the hall table in four bundles, one for each month, each with a rubber band and a yellow sticky note: *February*, *March*, *April*, *May*. The plant on the windowsill—a pothos I had been failing to kill for years—had been watered so faithfully that it had put out a new vine and trained it along the curtain rail. The fridge held foods I don't buy: oat milk, a bag of washed spinach, little pots of yogurt with names like *Orchard*. The calendar on the kitchen wall still said February. Nell hadn't turned it. I didn't know whether that was tact or superstition, and I didn't turn it either.

"I'll stay till the end of the month," Nell said. She had her back to me, pouring water. "Work's fine about it. Graham's fine about it."

"You don't have to."

"I know I don't have to."

"I just mean you've already—"

"I know what you mean."

What I meant, I think, was two things at once. I meant: go home, back to your own kitchen and the husband you've been talking to on speakerphone since winter, so that I can find out what I'm like when nobody is watching. And I meant: please don't. I couldn't have said which was louder. She put a cup of tea in front of me, in a white mug she must have brought from home, and sat down across the table with hers, and we drank them, and neither of us said anything else about it.

MY FRIEND THEO called at four.

"You're home," he said. "How is it? How are you feeling?"

"Good," I said. "Really good. It's strange, but a good strange. It's very quiet."

All of that was true, the way a postcard is true. I was sitting on the bottom stair because it was the nearest place to sit when the phone rang, and while we talked I had been looking at the other thirteen and thinking about them in a way I had never thought about stairs. Not with fear. More the way you might look at a long sentence in a language you used to speak well.

"You sound tired," Theo said.

"I'm on the stairs," I said, as if that explained it, and he laughed, and I laughed, and he told me about a man at his office who had started bringing a standing desk to meetings, and I said all the right things in the right places. When we hung up I stayed where I was. Then I went up, one hand on the rail, and at the top I sat down on the landing carpet, which is not a thing adults do in their own homes, and waited until I was ready for whatever came next.

Nell found me there on her way to the bathroom.

"Oh," she said.

"I'm just sitting."

"Okay." She stepped over my legs, carefully, and then stopped and came back and sat down beside me, her knees up near her chin the way she used to sit when we were children watching television through the banisters. She didn't ask anything. After a minute she said, "This carpet is disgusting, by the way," and I said, "I know," and that was, somehow, the best conversation I'd had all day.

THE MUGS WERE the thing that went wrong.

It was early evening. Nell was in the backyard on the phone to Graham, walking up and down the path, and I decided I would make the tea. It seemed a manageable ambition. I filled the kettle—the kettle was where it lived—and switched it on, and then I reached up to the cabinet above the toaster, where my mugs had been since the day I moved in, and opened it, and found cans of soup.

The mugs were in the cabinet under the counter, on the lower shelf, lined up in two rows with their handles all facing the same way. So were the plates. So were the teapot and the honey and the tea itself. Everything I used every day had come down to waist height, and everything I didn't—the soup, the good glasses, a fondue set someone gave me years ago—had gone up.

I stood there with the cabinet door open for long enough that the kettle clicked off.

"You moved the mugs," I said when she came in.

She looked at the open cabinet, and then at me, and I watched her decide how to answer.

"I moved the things you use."

"I didn't ask you to."

"No," she said. "You weren't really in a position to be asked."

It came out sharper than she meant. I saw it reach her own face a second after it reached mine. She put her phone down on the counter.

"Sorry. That was—"

"It's fine."

"It isn't. I just thought, the first few weeks, you wouldn't want to be stretching up for things. I don't know. I read something."

"I can reach a cabinet, Nell."

"I know you can."

Neither of us knew that. That was the problem, underneath the mugs. I didn't know yet what I could do. For months, people had told me what I could do—sit up, stand, walk to the window, walk to the end of the corridor and back—and now I was home, where no one was going to tell me anything, and the first thing I'd found was that my sister had already guessed. She had guessed low. She might have been right.

Nell made the tea in the end. I let her.

That night I couldn't sleep, which everyone had warned me about, though not in a way that helped. The bed was too wide and the room was too dark, and the quiet pressed on my ears. For months I'd had a door that never quite closed, voices passing at all hours, a light in the corridor that stayed on. I had hated all of it. Now I lay in my own bed and missed it, and felt ridiculous, and then felt something underneath the ridiculousness that I didn't want to look at, and got up.

The landing light was on. Nell's door was half open and I could hear her talking, low, the way you talk at midnight to someone who is also in bed.

"I don't know," she was saying. "Says everything's fine. Says it all the time." A pause. "No. No, I'm not going to push. I'm just going to be here, that's all. I'm going to be in the kitchen."

I went back to bed before she could hear the floorboard outside the bathroom, which has creaked for as long as I've lived here and which I have never once remembered in time.

In the morning I was up first.

In May the light comes into the kitchen at an angle, across the table and up the side of the fridge, and I stood in it for a while in my socks. I didn't feel better, exactly. I

felt like someone who had slept four hours and would find out later what kind of day this was going to be. I had been told there would be good days and bad ones, and that the only way to know which was which was to get to the end of them.

I filled the kettle. I opened the cabinet under the counter and took two mugs from the lower shelf: my blue one with the chip in the rim, and Nell's white one from home. I put the milk in hers first, which I have always said is barbaric. I didn't put it in mine. Then I turned the calendar to May.

She came down at half past seven with her hair flattened on one side, saw the mug waiting at her place, and lifted it and looked at the color of it and said, "Milk first, you animal," and kissed the top of my head on her way to the toaster.

Afterward I washed both mugs and dried them and stood for a moment with the cabinet door open. Then I put them back on the lower shelf, handles facing the same way, where I would find them tomorrow.

End of excerpt. Chapter One of an imagined memoir, approximately 1,722 words.

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